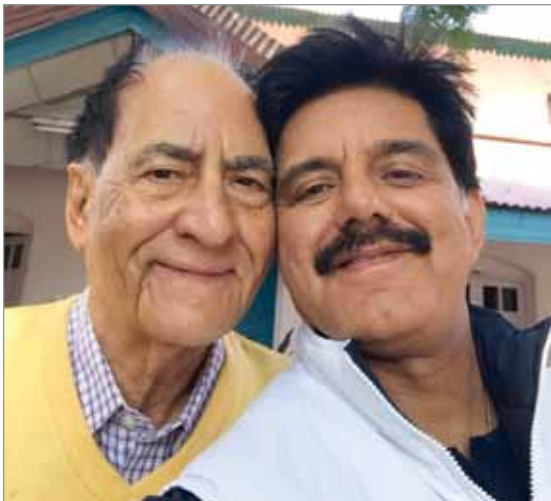




Vineet Sahni with his father IPS VP Sahni

But our personal car received no salutes because people salute positions, not people,” he said, adding that this was his first lesson about respect, positions, and people.

Furthermore, he advises, “As a CEO, MD, or another CXO, you must learn to keep your head straight and hopes high. These positions are not permanent; but the connections you build will always endure.”

First P&L lesson in college

Among the many lessons Sahni learned during his academic life is one where he realised that a person who prepares for success through hard work will always be the most content at the end of the day. He arrived at this insight through an analysis with schoolmates who

topped the class on one occasion.

He explains, “There are three types of top-ers: those who topped through year-long preparation, those who topped because exam questions came from specific chapters they studied, and those who topped by cheating!”

“The first ones will be the most content because they know hard work has no substitute. The second ones will fall when their luck

runs out. The third ones will always resort to cheating, and a day will come when they will be caught, and the world will stop believing in them,” he adds, noting that employees in corporate life and other segments of life are no different!

The knack for prudent financial management is one of the first things every manager needs to master to become a leader Sahni reflects on his early college days, where he made his first profit and loss decisions.

He shares, “There were times I had only ₹10 in my pocket with two to three days left for money to come from home. I could ask friends or family for money or manage with those ₹10. I always, and I mean always, chose the latter. Even if

it meant skipping a meal or having cheap roadside food—that’s the choice I made.”

Sahni adds, “In the business context today, that ₹10 sometimes becomes ₹200 crore, and those two days become three years; the thought process to overcome the financial challenge remains the same.”

Nothing substitutes hard work—early lessons in life

A lesson he learned when he was 15 years old: Due to the mid-term transfer, he had to change schools when he was in class 9. He could not cope with the change. His rank in class 9 was 35 out of 38 students, and he was given extra classes for being weak in mathematics. It was the feeling of humiliation. Determined to make a difference, he challenged the 9th class topper to beat him in class 10th Boards.

Determined to succeed, he made extraordinary efforts. He studied for an average of 12 hours a day, with no TV time, no outings, and no socialising. This focused and determined approach, coupled with extremely dedicated hard work, made him top the Boards in class 10 with a significant margin. “My name is still on the honours board in the school,” he says.

When asked whether it was just the focused hard work or some other factors too, with a smile, he says, “With hard work, you need the blessings of your elders and a dash of luck on your side.” “I still remember how my mom wore the same saree every day during the 10th Board exams. As the first day she wore that saree, I did very well in the exam. Those are the blessings and luck I was speaking about.

“However, luck and blessings follow efforts!”

14 clubs in a golf bag

While he played a lot of table tennis and badminton in his school and

Vineet Sahni’s guru mantras

- “Never manage or lead according to the last person you met or the last book you read.”
- “People respect positions and power, not other people.”
- “Build connections, but not just for the sake of business.”
- “Always back the dark horses.”
- “People at lowest designations speak the real truth.”
- “Organisation’s growth is directly proportional to every individual’s growth associated with it.”
- “When luck meets efforts, resonance happens.”
- “Results are past tense.”
- “Creating a great past is as much possible as creating a great future if you know how to live in the present.”
- “Never compromise on your self-respect.”